



CONCILIATORY GESTURE: To appease Congress, pro-LTTE leader Vaiko (L) was arrested

local leaders of DMK and AIADMK were killed. The slain DMK leader Poondi K. Kalaiselvan was the district secretary of the ruling party. This has further added to the troubles that Karunanidhi is already facing since he also holds the home portfolio.

"The police are aware about the activities of these killers but they seldom act. Until the link between the police and the criminals is broken, there would be no let up in such crimes," says S. Ramadoss, the founder of PMK, an ally of the DMK both at the state and the Centre. A few weeks earlier, six people were killed in Thenkasi after a communal clash turned violent. "During Jayalalithaa's rule, her party's second-rung leaders hesitated in intervening in police matters," says an intelligence official on condition of anonymity. In the DMK regime, even district and taluk level officials of the party interfere in policemen's work on behalf of the accused.

If the violence wasn't bad enough, Karunanidhi also has to grapple with his coalition partners on their charges of the Government not being vigilant enough in curbing activities ranging from smuggling of ration rice meant for fair price shops to illegal sand quarrying that is now said to be rampant. Further embarrassment has come in

MOUNTING WOES

RELIGIOUS CLASH: In Thenkasi, Hindu-Muslim clashes resulted in six deaths.

LOCK-UP DEATH: A Neyveli Lignite employee was allegedly killed at Kullanchavadi police station.

WEAPON CULTURE: The number of incidents involving usage of weapons like guns and remote-controlled bombs has increased.

PRO-TIGERS ROW: The Congress is unhappy with the party ever since the chief minister wrote a poem eulogising slain LTTE leader Thamilselvan.

UNLAWFUL ACTIVITIES: Not only the Opposition but even the coalition partners accuse the Government of not curbing illegal sand quarrying and ration rice smuggling.

the form the Union Health Minister Anbumani Ramadoss, a vocal proponent of the anti-tobacco campaign, stating publicly that Karunanidhi was among the politicians who had asked him not to clamp down on the tobacco industry. Besides, statements made by the DMK chief on the Ram Sethu issue have ruffled quite a few feathers at the Centre. With Gujarat elections approaching, the Congress fears that the saffron camp will capitalise on the issue to win votes. But even before the issue could be brushed under the

carpet, DMK and Congress were involved in another skirmish after Karunanidhi, in his frequent attempts at putting pen to paper, eulogised the slain LTTE leader S.P. Thamilselvan.

That was the gravest provocation for the Congress leadership which carries the burden of aligning with a party whose sympathy for the LTTE's cause is well known and whose leaders were indicted in the Jain Commission report for the assassination of former Congress president and prime minister Rajiv Gandhi. At the AICC meet held in Delhi last week, party leaders were angry

enough to have a resolution passed to the effect that any pro-LTTE statement will be considered an attempt to hurt the sentiments of the Congress. As Union minister of state for textiles, E.V.K.S. Elangovan said, "It is worrying to see a DMK Government, running on the support of the Congress, continuing to make statements in favour of LTTE."

As if to make amends, Karunanidhi arrested DMK chief Vaiko and Tamil National Movement chief P. Nedumaran—both Congress baiters. Echoing the Government's change of mood, Tamil Nadu's DGP Rajendran issued a statement last week: "Those who conduct rallies, public meetings, protests, burn effigies...in support of banned organisations will be dealt with severely under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act 1967."

But even at the local level, DMK has little reason to cheer. There is a widespread feeling that DMK chief Vijayakant and AISMK chief Sarath Kumar—both popular actors with considerable fan following—are poaching youth votes with their iconoclastic statements. To counter this perception, DMK has hurried up the youth wing conference in Tirunelveli. Party officials say that this will also be touted as a show of strength for chief-minister-in-waiting Stalin. However, considering the state of DMK and Tamil Nadu, such efforts are unlikely to bear fruit at this moment. ■